

Mains Master Program 2024: Art and Culture (GS1)

Handout 4: Archaeological and Literary Sources

Q. As a source material for the study of ancient India, inscriptions can prove to be very valuable source material. Examine.

Inscriptions are a valuable source of information for the study of ancient India. They can provide us with a wealth of data on a wide range of topics, including:

- **Political history:** Inscriptions can tell us about the **names** and **reigns** of rulers, the **extent** of their empires, and their military **campaigns**.
- **Administrative structure:** Furthermore, inscriptions offer insights into the administrative systems of ancient India. They can provide details about the governance structure, legal codes, and land grants, shedding light on the political and economic organization of the time.
- **Socio-economic history:** Inscriptions can shed light on the **social structure** of ancient India, including the **caste** system, the status of **women**, and the nature of **land** ownership. They can also provide information on the **economy**, **trade**, and **commerce**.
- **Religious history:** Inscriptions can tell us about the **major religions** of ancient India, including Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism. They can also provide information on the religious **practices** of the time, **rituals**, **patronage** as well as the role of religion in society.
- **Cultural history:** Inscriptions can provide us with insights into the culture of ancient India, including **art**, **architecture**, **literature**, and **music**. They can also provide information on the everyday life of people in ancient India.

Of course, no source of information is perfect, and inscriptions are no exception. They can be **difficult to decipher**, and they may be **biased** or **incomplete**. However, when used carefully, inscriptions can provide us with a valuable and reliable glimpse into the past.

Practice:

Q. Epigraphic sources are the best reflections of ancient Indian art and culture. Comment.



Q. Do you think that in the reconstruction of Early Indian religious and cultural history, coins are extremely helpful?

Introductions:

- The study of coins, called numismatics, can help in the reconstruction of not only political and economic history but also socio-cultural and religious history of the past.
- **Source-based:** In the study of early Indian history, two types of sources are used: literary and archaeological. Study of coins, called Numismatics, falls in the archaeological sources and acts as a very important source for the reconstruction of history.
- **Comparative:**
 - In the reconstruction of the religious and cultural history of ancient India, the relative dearth of textual material can be partly compensated by a numerous and diverse coins from all parts of India.
 - Coins as important source of history as they add, confirm, modify or amplify the data from other sources.

Religious History:

- **Royal policies and patronage:**
 - Kings issue coins with the portraits from the **popular religion**
 - Vaishnavism of Gupta coins
 - **Titles** of the kings: Divine kingship and religious/cultic affiliations
 - Personal religious **preference** of the kings
 - Gupta Kings performing Ashvamedha sacrifice
 - **Religious syncretism:**
 - Portraits of Greek, Iranian, Buddhist and Brahmanical gods on **Kushana coins**
- **History of religious cults**
 - **Geographic and chronological spread** of cults
 - Coins of **Agathocles** from **Ai-Khanoum**: cult that emanated from Mathura region had already reached north Afghanistan in 2nd century BCE
 - **Development of religious:**
 - **Shaivite pantheon** of Uma, Vishakha, Kartikeya, Skanda etc in Kushana coins
 - Copper coins of Kanishka show **Bodhisattva Maitreya**
 - Goddesses on the coins in the early medieval East India: **Tantricism**
 - **Development of iconographic forms**
 - Representation of Buddha in human form is first noticed on the coins of **Kushanas**.
 - The earliest depiction of **Shiva** in human form with four hands is seen on the coins of Kanishka while that of **Vishnu** with four hands is seen on the coins of Vasudeva.
 - **Evolution of mythology**
 - **Motifs** such as Nandipada, Trishula, Garuda

Culture:

- **Language and script**
 - **Paleography:** James Princep used Indo-Greek coins to decipher Kharoshthi and Brahmi script
- **Artistic Workmanship:** Coins are great works of artistic merit in some cases
 - eg excellent/beautiful gold coins of the Guptas

- **Artistic realism/style: Portraits** of the kings and other figures reflect the artistic styles.
 - Eg. Hellenistic art in the Indo-Bactrian coins, Satavahanas portrait coins present realistic picture of the kings, Gupta gold coins also have artistic realism.
- **Cultural assimilation**
 - Indo-Greek coins offer an example of how the people of patently non-Indian origin and culture were being Indianized when they moved south of Hindukush. Later Shaka coins indicate their complete absorption into the fold of Hinduism based on names of kings.
- **Cross-Cultural interaction**
 - Satavahana portraits - cultural influence of Roman coins

Conclusions:

- Yet to study/classify, still new hoards and chance finds, emerging technologies/models for better analysis – even better use
- Not in isolation but in corroboration – great source

Practice:

Q. How can the economy of the ancient Indian empires be examined with the help of coins?

Q. The strict division of Indian literature as secular or religious is not very tenable. Do you agree? Illustrate.

Religious scriptures (eg Rigved, Guru Granth Sahib) are central to the belief system of a religion while secular literature deals with everything apart from religion – aspects of the daily life of people and socio-economy, politics, culture, science and aesthetics. Arthashastra of Chanakya, Kamasutra of Vatsyayana, Mahabhashya of Patanjali and Meghdootam of Kalidas are some examples.

However, when one looks at the content of all these books, it is apparent that such strict religious-secular separation is not really present.

Secular inside Religious:

- **Rigveda** deals with many aspects which are not religious. The religious hymns mention social relationships of this world, tribal wars, political structures, trade, flora/fauna, geography etc.
- **Atharvaveda** is full of charms and magic spells – alluding to popular psychology at that time.
- **Shulba Sutras** that were composed to describe the construction of fire altars for sacrifice also discuss geometry.
- **Dharmashastras** give norms to regulate social affairs. Thus, they mention marriage, family, divorce, inheritance, interest rates, criminal law as well as duties of kings.
- Many **Puranas** contained appendices like Chitrastutras or Shilpasutras that dealt with the artforms like paintings or trades like architecture.
- Many **bhakti compositions** use social relationships allegorically and also give information about mundane material activities of daily life.

Religious inside Secular:

On the other hand, the so-called secular literature too – which dealt with either aesthetics, politics, science, linguistics, grammar, poetics, drama as well as philosophy – contained not only references and allusions but also main themes related to religious beliefs and patterns.

- **Arthashastra**, a treatise on statecraft, elaborates on how and where a temple should be located in a city.
- Panini describes the notational system in his **Ashtadhyayi** in the form of Shiva Sutras.
- Patanjali's **Mahabhashya**, which is about Sanskrit vyakarana, gives many stories of yakshas.
- Bharata's **Natyashastra**, the dramaturgical thesis, speaks about the origin of all the artforms and rasas with Brahma. A performance was considered as one way of worship.
- **Manimekalai** and **Shilappadikaram** express as much about the contemporary south Indian society as about Buddhist and Jaina belief systems.
- Kalidasa's epic poem **Kumarsambhavam** is about the story of Kartikeya, the son of Shiva and Parvati.
- The books on **agricultural technology** and practices give prayers for a better harvest and the books on astronomy deal with religious cosmology too.

It can thus be seen that there is hardly any strict line of separation between the two domains – religious and secular.

Q. How far does Kautilyan Arthashastra work as a source of history for the Mauryan period?

Kautilyan Arthashastra is a text of an encyclopedic nature which described comprehensively political, social and cultural life. But considering its nature, we need to be cautious as well while using it as a source of study.

As a source of history, it sheds light on the political, economic and foreign affairs of the era. Incidentally, it also provides information of socio-cultural nature.

- Duty of the king, a king who is much active like Chandragupta
- Administrative hierarchy and functions of the state
- Economy - no other ancient book as detailed
- Social - varna, caste, women - it throws light on them
- Picture of contemporary religious sects

However, we have to be careful about directly using it as a source of Mauryan history.

- There is a lack of clarity regarding time, space and authorship.
 - Kautilyan Arthashastra is not written in one single period, but it has various interpolations. Vast portions of the book actually belong to the post-Mauryan era.
 - Similarly, the biographic details of Kautilya are hard to come by.
- Theoretical orientation:
 - It doesn't talk about the present, it's futuristic in orientation. It is not a history book but an ideal state in hypothetical scenarios.
- Thirdly, in some places, even Brahmanic biases/prejudices are expressed.

Conclusion:

- That's why needed to corroborate with other contemporary sources.

Q. To what extent Megasthenes' descriptions of Indian society and economy can be used to reconstruct ancient Indian history?

Introductions:

- Megasthenes came to India as an ambassador of ... in the court of ... wrote the book... which is used as a source of history of the Mauryan era. By comparing it with other contemporary evidence, like Arthashastra, Ashokan edicts and other archaeological evidence, the usefulness of the account can be established.
- Throughout the history of India, many foreign accounts.... which illuminate aspects of history... but also limited by the author's bias, access, understanding of local culture and target audience etc. Megasthenes Indica too...

Connecting Line:

Megasthenes' Indica described India, its size and shape, rivers, soil, climate, plants, animals, produce, administration, society, and also provided many legends. Some of these can be corroborated with the help of other Indian sources.

Facts that can be corroborated:

- Village and district level officers for revenue collection and other things (Agronomoi etc. are named with other titles in Arthashastra/Ashokan edicts)
- Growing rice/millet twice a year (matches with the climate)
- Farmers not harmed in war (matches with Arthashastra)
- Endogamy (matches with the description of caste system)
- India originally inhabited by primitive tribes
- Indians' worship of Dionysus and Herakles (Vasudeva Krishna).
- Views of the 'Brachmanes' (Brahmanas) relating to the nature of the world and soul.

Views which cannot be corroborated:

- No slavery in India (slavery chapter in Arthashastra)
- Seven castes in India (more of Egypt than India)
- All land owned by king (Arthashastra mentions land ownership disputes, Queens Edict in Allahabad mentions gift of garden, Pali literature is full of stories with private ownership of land)
- Theft is rare/absent in India (entire chapter on criminal punishment in Arthashastra. Statistics cannot be corroborated.)
- No famines in India (great famine in Magadha, Sohgura/Mahasthangarh inscription)
- Simple/frugal people not wearing jewellery (Didarganj Yakshi sculpture)
- No written laws (all by memory? Arthashastra talks about state archive),
- Indians didn't know the art of writing (Ashokan edicts..!)
- Indians didn't borrow/lent money on interest (Arthashastra gives rules to regulate lending),
- Fanciful/Mythological ideas (people with backward feet, gold-digging ants, unicorn horses, huge snakes, dog-headed men) (Strabo himself calls Megasthenes a liar..!)

Analytical Perspective:

Megasthenes has tendency to romanticize, idealize and even mythify certain aspects of life in India, either because of genuine misunderstanding or he wanted to contrast them with those practices which he disapproved in his own society.

- Tendency to **romanticize**/idealize.
- **Ignorance:** To what extent is first-hand knowledge? Restricted exposure both socially and geographically being a royal ambassador himself.
- Being a **foreigner** who lacked a proper understanding of the local context, he often misinterpreted what he saw.
- **Not surviving completely** – not exactly a primary source. Original text is not available.
- **Later authors:**
 1. Selectivism, exaggeration, entertainment purpose (target audience and purpose)
 2. Double filter: Megasthenes' interpretation; later Graeco-Roman writers' interpretations.

Conclusions:

- Certain limitations due to it being a foreign source but with corroboration/juxtaposition, its value is unlocked.
- Despite inconsistencies and fragmentary survival, it is still an eyewitness account. If less about India, more valuable as a source of what others thought of India.

Q. The Sangam literature portrays the social and economic conditions of its time with remarkable vividness. Comment.

Social conditions:

- **Caste/Class:**
 - Initially horizontally divided into 5 ecozone - kurunji, mullai, palai, neytal, marutam.
 - Gradual emergence of varna-based society. But unlike north India, there was two-fold division: Brahmin and non-Brahmins.
 - Brahmins enjoyed the superior status and held government offices. Their importance increased with the growing popularity of large-scale Vedic rituals. However, unlike in north India, there was no taboo against the consumption of alcohol or meat.
 - Tolkappiyam names four castes: Arasar (rulers), Anthanar (priests), Vanigar (traders and merchants) and Vellalar (agriculturists). This seems more like occupational division.
 - The society had a complex class structure as well. The rich lived in well decorated brick houses and wore costly clothing, but the poor lived in mud huts and had scanty clothes to wear.
 - Slavery was practiced.
- **Women and family: Women status much better.**
 - Chastity was worshipped by people.
 - Love marriage acceptable, freedom to choose life partner.
 - Marriage institution recently introduced.
 - Practice of Sati in the higher strata of society.
- **Other important features**
 - Warrior ethic, hero stones, Vattakirutal, death rituals
 - Education: Katikai
 - Women poets like Avvaiyar, Nachchellaiyar, and Kakkaiyapadiniyar
 - Culture, poetry, Literature: stages of love, stages of war, emotions, stock phrases
- **Religious pluralism**
 - Tinai: diversity of belief system
 - Animism dominant trend.
 - Funerary practices diversity (urn, cremation, exposure)
 - As per Sangam texts, both Vedic tradition and non-Vedic sentiments existed. Vedic Deities (Shiva, Krishna-Mayon, Lakshmi-Tiru) and Indigenous deities Murugan (later Skanda-Kartikaya), Korravai (later Durga)
 - Philosophy (ideas of karma, reincarnation) and sacrifices (Rajasuya yajna).
 - The Epic tradition was known and referred to in the poetry.
 - Both Jainism and Buddhism reached by 1st c CE and were the dominant religions till Pallava era.

Economic conditions:

- **Agri mainstay but trade and craft doing well.**
 - **Paddy and sugarcane** were the two main crops cultivated in a large quantity.
 - The kings of the Sangam age took great **measures** for the development of agriculture. **Tank irrigation** helped in feeding agriculture as mentioned in many poems. **Karikala Chola**

dug tanks for irrigation and his embankment of the river Cauvery proved to be very useful for agriculture.

- Agriculture was supplemented by **cattle rearing**. One of the primary duties of the king was to protect the cattle of his kingdom.
- **Craft**
 - The **handicrafts** of the Sangam period were popular. They include **weaving, metal works, carpentry, ship building and making of ornaments** using beads, stones and ivory.
 - Spinning and weaving of **cotton and silk** clothes attained a high quality. It was a household industry in which both men and women participated.
 - According to *Silappadikaram*, men of different occupations lived in different streets.
 - **Paripadal** refers to the existence of a museum of **paintings** in Madura (Madurai) and the sale of pictures is mentioned by *Silappadikaram*.
- **Chief feature: Indo-Roman trade**
 - The literary works like *Silappadikaram*, *Manimekalai* and *Pattinappalai* frequently refer to the contact with the Greek and Roman traders.
 - Important ports- Puhar, Tondi, Muzhiris, Korkai, Arikamedu
 - The **Periplus of Erythrean Sea** and Pliny, Ptolemy, Strabo and Petronius mention various **ports and the articles traded** during the period.
 - Commodities
 - Major exports- pepper, ginger, cardamom, cinnamon and turmeric along with ivory products, pearls and precious stones.
 - Major imports- horses, gold, and sweet wine.
 - Trade-surplus.
 - Plenty of **gold coins** issued by the Roman Emperors like Augustus, Tiberius and Nero were found in all parts of Tamil Nadu.
- **Urbanization** – emerging urban centres and markets (Kanchipuram, Karur etc)

Q. Highlight the achievements of the Gupta period in the field of literature.

Introductions:

- The Gupta period (c. 300-600 CE) is known for its remarkable achievements in all fields of arts and literature of variety of kinds, including literature.
- Sanskrit reached its zenith/climax due to active royal patronage of Guptas. And even in the local/common level – thus usage in the Royal Prashastis.
- Golden period: due to high watermark of cultural achievements
- Classical period: high aesthetic achievement in all types of literary genres – and set a very high standard for the future.

Religious-Philosophical:

- Epics and Puranas – reached their final form.
 - Ramayana/Mahabharata/Puranas
 - Philosophy, tradition, common wisdom, mythology, moral codes
 - Meant for education, improvement as well as entertainment
- Smritis/Dharmashastra – Encoded social and religious norms. Extended the realm of Dharasutras further

- Narada, Katyayana
- Philosophical
- Buddhist – Even Buddhists turned to Sanskrit
 - Vasubandhu Abhidharma-koshakarika, and his half brother Asanga – both for Mahayana

Aesthetic/Creative:

- Drama - These plays have happy endings, and no tragedies are found. Characters of women and Shudras featured speak in Prakrit, whereas the higher classes use Sanskrit.
 - Vishakhadatta – Mudrarakshasa, Devi Chandraguptam
 - Shudraka – Mrichhakatikam
 - Kalidasa's compositions + Navaratna in the court
- Poetry
 - Kalidasa
 - Bhartrihari's Shatakas
- Prose - Quality of prose that was urbane in essence and ornate in character.
 - Vatsyana's Kamasutra
 - Harishena's Prashasti
 - Panchatantra

Technical/Scientific: Extended the older tradition of Sanskrit grammar, etymological work, dictionaries, aesthetics and scientific treatises.

- Grammar – Bhartrihari's Vakyapadiya
- Lexicon – Amarkosha by Amarsinha
- Polity – Kamandaka's Nitisastra
- Science – Aryabhatta, Varahamihira, Sushruta

Prakrit:

- Development of Shauraseni Prakrit (Middle phase)
- Maharashtri Prakrit – Setubandha of Pravarasena II Vakataka king

Conclusions:

- Thus, all round development in this era. Certainly a high point.
- So much beautiful in all spheres – set the standards for future. (classical age)
- Later era decline – ornate style

Q. Discuss the reasons behind emergence of vernacular languages during early medieval India.

During early medieval period, the linguistic landscape of India transformed with the rise of regional languages. Although Tamil and Kannada had had early start, various other languages like Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati, Telugu began to flourish now. The reasons for this change are as follows:

- There was **gradual decline in the quality of Sanskrit** literature set in during early medieval era.
- **The growth of a feudal society** played a crucial role in fostering regional identities. Feudal era, with focus more on agriculture and less on long-distance trade, led to the development of distinct regional cultures.
- **Regional powers:**
 - Regional courts and local elites began to promote vernacular languages, both in administration and literary production.
 - These kingdoms needed efficient administration and communication within their territories. Vernacular languages, being more widely understood than Sanskrit, became a natural choice for administrative purposes.
 - To gain legitimacy, the regional elites often instrumentalized regional languages to appeal to local people, reinforce their regional-cultural identity.
- **Bhakti Movements:**
 - Since Bhakti saints aimed for mass appeal, they used vernaculars to compose songs, poems, and teachings. This religious content in the everyday language helped vernacular languages gain prestige and standardization.
 - Bhakti saints also translated and adapted major Sanskrit texts like the Epics, Puranas, and the Bhagavad Gita into regional languages, making these works accessible to the masses.
 - Similarly, Buddhist Siddhas and Nathpanthis played an important role in the rapid growth of regional literature.

Thus, early medieval period laid the foundation for the rich diversity of languages and regional identities seen today.

Q. Discuss how the Bhakti movement gave thrust to vernacular languages.

Introductions:

Bhakti movement, which laid stress on emotional connect with personal god through simple means, challenged the orthodoxy. To make their teachings more accessible to the people, they discarded the use of Sanskrit/Persian and used the language of common people.

OR

Prior to the emergence of the Bhakti movement, Sanskrit was the dominant language for religious and literary expression, accessible only to a select few. However, the Bhakti saint-poets broke away from this tradition and chose to express through vernaculars.

- **Bengali:** Bengali was used by Chaitanya and by the poet Chandidas, who wrote extensively on the theme of the love of Radha and Krishna.
- **Assamese:** Bhakti leader Shankaradeva popularized the use of Assamese in the Brahmaputra valley in the 15th century. He used an entirely new medium to spread his ideas. He wrote a number of plays, incorporating themes from the Puranas.
- **Odiya:** Chaitanya spent his last year at Puri and encouraged his followers to use Oriya in preference to Sanskrit. The Jagannath temple at Puri has a collection of manuscripts which date from the twelfth century and language of these contain elements of what was later to develop as Oriya, the language of the region.
- **Maithili:** The development of Maithili, spoken in the region of modern Bihar, was also associated with Vaishnava and Bhakti literature. Bhakti saint Vidyapati used Maithili extensively to write verses on Goddess Kali.
- **Marathi:** Marathi reached its apogee at the hands of Eknath and Tukaram. Tukaram's teachings were in form of dohas which constitute the Gatha. Guru Ramdas wrote Dasbodh in Marathi.
- **Punjabi:** Nath saints' works in early 11th century were associated with Punjabi language. The Janamsakhis stories on the life and legend of Guru Nanak are early examples of Punjabi prose literature.
- **Kannada:** Sarvajna wrote three-liner philosophical poems in Kannada. His triplets known as Vachans, were sung, quoted, recited and set to kolata or play of sticks with music, as they are rhythmic.
- **Other regional languages:** Kabir wrote Bijak and Sakhi in Mizapuri dialect of Hindi.

Conclusions:

Thus, by embracing regional languages, the movement not only made religious ideas accessible to a wider audience but also contributed to the development of vernacular literature.

OR

Such literary output not only enriched the vernacular languages but also established a distinct literary tradition. Many Bhakti poets are revered as literary figures, and their works continue to be celebrated in the respective regional languages to this day.

OR

Such development of regional languages due to Bhakti movement not only helped in wide circulation of the reformist Bhakti ideas among people, but also led to the emergence of regional identity and pride of in their cultural heritage.

Q. Examine Alberuni's assessment of the Indian society/religion.

(A) Society:

- **Caste system**

1. Mentions **purush-sukta**: discusses origin of 4 varnas.
2. He mentions that members of each **varna** are forbidden to dine with members of other varnas.
 1. He says that Brahmins get privileges over others.
3. **Proliferation of castes**: 4 Varnas and 8 Antyaja castes are mentioned by him.
 1. Ibn Khordabdeh before him mentioned 7 castes
 2. Kalhan mentions 64 castes
 3. Brahmapurana mentions hundred castes
4. **Equality: Shudra=vaishya**
 1. Both of them were allowed to live in forts, sarais, towns etc but none of them given right to recite/hear vedas.
 2. Matches with some puranas and Kalhana. Feature of feudal age.
5. **Untouchability**
 1. He was shocked to see untouchability
 2. They reside near villages and towns but not within them.
 3. They have specific professions like shoemaking etc.
6. He **despises lack of social mobility** for meritorious individuals and contrasts it with the sense of equality among Muslims.

- **Condition of Women**

1. Mentions Sati system in palaces, child marriage and dowry practices, deplorable condition of widows
2. On the other hand, he reports that the people are not very severe in punishing whoredom.
3. He also refers to the practice of temple women singing and dancing which may be a reference to Devadasis.

(B) Knowledge system

- **Condition of Knowledge**

1. Alberuni tells us about the rich scientific knowledge and literature possessed by the Hindus of his age. Saying that Hindus have numerous branches of knowledge, he makes a special mention of the physical sciences, including biology, physics, medicine which were fairly advanced.
2. 'number of Hindu sciences is great but the science of astronomy is the most famous and the most cherished of all.'
 1. He has provided quotes from Aryabhatta, Brahmagupta, Varahamihira.
3. Mathematics was also highly developed in India.
 1. He even mentioned the value of Pie calculated by Brahmagupta.

- **Conservative Attitude**

1. Insular, narrow-minded, superiority complex, arrogant, think of others as inferiors
2. Hindus don't share knowledge with their own countrymen.
3. Stagnation of knowledge. Now they don't have idea of the outside world.
4. Their forefathers were more liberal, aware of the world and not close-minded.

(C) Religious beliefs and practices of the Hindus.

- He uses word **Hindu** in a generic sense, for all Indians
- He refers to **polytheism, monotheism**, and compares Hindu Trimurti with Christian Trinity.
- Alberuni also refers to the **Buddha** as an avatara of Vishnu.
- He not only **quoted from scriptures** (Upanishads, Patanjali, Puranas) but also mentioned various **concepts** (karma, moksha, svarga, narka) and **vratas**.
- Detailed information about various **festivals** (eg Diwali, Shiv Ratri) and associated mythologies.
- Mentions **Tirthas/pilgrimage** centres like Kurukshetra, Banares, Kannauj, Thanesar etc.
- He had reverence for **Benares**. He said that Benares was so sacred that even if a criminal enters the city, he would be absolved of the crime.
- He says that not all Brahmins **recite the Vedas** with its proper understanding.

Critical Analysis:

- We don't have detailed **clarity of time and space**.
- Highlighted socio-cultural history but **not political-economic history**.
- **Bookish**, scripture-based understanding.
- **Language** issue
- Factually incorrect **cross-cultural** analysis.
- Some **wrong observations**.

Conclusion:

In spite of the limitations, it is still relatively better. We still depend on it for the better understanding of society and culture of north India in the early 11th century.

Q. Identify the different categories of Persian literature which emerged during the Delhi Sultanate.

Foundation of Delhi Sultanate in 1206 led to emergence of new elites in India and thus a new elite culture, which was dominated by Persian language. This foreign language flourished in the soil of India and led to the creation of variety of literary genres.

- **History/Tarikhs:** Sultanate introduced systematic history writing practice. Various historians, like Afif and Barani, were sponsored by the court to write official histories in Persian. These histories give a glimpse of life of Persian elites.
- **Official documents:** Firmans, parwanas, dasturs and hukums, which were the official orders of variety of types, provide access to how the Persianate official work was carried out.
- **Insha:** the collection of letters, which survive, among the elites give a glimpse of universe of officialdom.
- **Autobiography:** Sultans like Firuz Shah Tughlaq even wrote an autobiography. Such books act as a direct window into the mind of the rulers.
- **Poems:** Various poetic formats like Masnavis, Rang, Qaul etc by famous poets like Amir Khusro in Persian added a new vigour in the poetry. Amir Khusro even created a new style of Farsi writing in India called as **Sabaq-i-Hindi** which continued to bloom for centuries.
- **Sufi texts:** Malfuzat literature, which had the sermons and discussion by Sufi masters and Maktubat, the letters written by Sufis, were also important. These writing throw floodlight on the life of common masses. E.g. Amir Hasan Sijzi's Fawaid-ul-Fawad.
- **Translations:** Books from various languages were translated into Persian and enriched Indian Persian literary universe. It included Arabic books like Kitab-ul-Hind or Sanskrit treatises on music and history.

Thus, it can be seen that Persian gradually developed in India as a language of elites as well as common people. It was able to express dry official prose as well as poetic emotions of common people. Not only that, in the coming centuries, the words and literary formats of Persian also enriched various Indian languages.

Practice Question:

Q. Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment.